Right from the start you know that he's going after the bowlers, and while that means that he can offer up a chance or two early on, that is something of a rare occurrence, as the Proteas found out too.

I mean, people reckon that I am a fairly attacking Test batsman, but compared to Ponting, I always feel tentative. Ponting believes the ball is there to be hit and that runs are there to be plundered.

It's that Australian mentality, isn't it? As sportsmen and -women, they just ooze confidence, which I believe is instilled in them at an early age. You can see it in their youngsters, and I've even seen it in the fans at the games. These little pikkies are, like, seven or eight years old and they're chirping you from the stands! I remember this one youngster at a game in Adelaide: I was walking onto the field with Mark Boucher and I hear this loud voice shouting, 'Hey, Gibbs … "Gibbs" me your autograph!' It's this little oke who can't be more than seven. Mark and I just laughed. I think the Australians are just brought up with all that cockiness and self-belief.

And as they get older, their confidence just increases. That may be the reason why young Aussies who break into the national team don't seem to struggle as much as we do. Their self-confidence is already sky-high, so they struggle less when they have to make an adjustment into Test cricket. In fact, the Aussies don't really stand back in any sport, and they never shy away from a challenge. Not only do they always go after the bowling, but they are also bladdy hard to get out.

Back to Ricky Ponting, though – he is as aggressive as he is focused as a batsman. I also think he's very aware of Steve Waugh's legacy and, like Waugh, he's not one for going out and partying too much with the boys. Brett 'Binga' Lee – one of the Aussies I have got to know pretty well – tells me Ponting is very chilled-out and relaxed off the field, but he doesn't often party with the team. According to Binga, when Ponting first took over as captain, he would never go out with his teammates, though it's a little better these days.

I remember bumping into Ponting and some of the team at Caprice in Camps Bay when we played them in the 2009 series. I had a few drinks and kept on ragging him, saying, 'Punter' – everyone calls him that – 'Punter, nice to see you out with your boys.' Every time I saw him, I made a point of saying the same thing. Every time he just smiled.

**Glenn McGrath**